

When more is less: historical linguistics and the commentaries on the Armenian τέχνη γραμματική

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Overview

Armenian & Greek: an overview

The *Yunaban Dproc*[‘]

The τέχνη γραμματική ...

...its Armenian translation ...

...and later commentaries

Conclusions

Armenian: a minimalist overview

- ▶ Armenian is an Indo-European language, *maybe* most closely related to Greek, Phrygian, Albanian (Pontic Group; for isoglosses, cf. HOLST 2009; more critically CLACKSON 1994; OLSEN AND THORSØ 2022)
- ▶ originally spoken in the Armenian Highlands, delimited by the Caucasus and Taurus Mountains, the Upper Euphrates and Media Atropatene
- ▶ recognised first as a people in the Behistun inscription (c. 520 BCE)
- ▶ first attested c. 480 CE (Sinai inscriptions, STONE 1990), first MS c. 9th century
- ▶ in comparison to other Indo-European languages, Armenian has undergone significant and partly intriguing sound changes (cf. OLSEN 1999:iv; MACAK 2017) and significant remodelling of its morphology (KLEIN 2017) owing to final apocope

Armenian & its external influences

- ▶ Armenian was thought to belong to Iranian phylum until HÜBSCHMANN (1875)
- ▶ it has undergone strong influence from Iranian languages (mainly Western Middle Iranian) in many categories: phonology, lexicon, derivational morphology, syntax
- ▶ since MEILLET (1911–1912) it has been clear that the main influence from Parthian (North West Middle Iranian; BOLOGNESI 1960)
- ▶ statistics suggest that only 22% of Classical Armenian vocabulary (as per HÜBSCHMANN's 1897 analysis) are *echtarmenisch*, more than 30% Parthian (BELARDI 2003:98–102)
- ▶ the linguistic influence from other languages such as Old Georgian, Syriac, or Urartian pales in comparison (DIAKONOV 1985; GREPPIN 1996; GREPPIN AND DIAKONOFF 1991; SIMON 2022)

Armenian & Greek

- ▶ most of the Greek material retained in Armenian belongs to the so-called 'Hellenising School' (on which more later), which have helped in the creation of a technical language for philosophy, theology, science and grammar
- ▶ non-scientific loans are usually restricted to specific lexical fields, largely essential terms of Christian religion and Byzantine administrative structures
- ▶ they are numerically more limited than Iranian loans (cf. OLSEN 1999: Greek 123 vs Iranian 728)

C'è una differenza sostanziale tra gli uni e gli altri: i prestiti di origine greca sono essenzialmente termini dotti mutuati prevalentemente, se non esclusivamente, dalla lingua scritta, e spesso documentati come semplici ἁπλᾶ λεγόμενα (a volte anzi si ha persino l'impressione che più che prestiti siano delle semplici trascrizioni di parole greche); i prestiti di origine iranica sono invece soprattutto costituiti da vocaboli fondamentali di uso comune nella vita di tutti i giorni, derivati dalla lingua viva e parlata.

(BOLOGNESI 1990:300)

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- ▶ *vkay* 'witness' > 'martyr' under influence of μάρτυς; *erēc* 'elder' > 'priest' via πρεσβύτερος; *anun* 'name' > 'noun' due to ὄνομα

The Lehnwörter are words that really entered the commonly used language; the Fremd-wörter belong instead to the written language: they are used in literary works, or are high-register words without circulation in the common language; finally we have words that represent the simple quotation of some Greek terms, used in works translated from Greek as a pure transcription of technical terms for which it was impossible to find or create an equivalent Armenian term.

Short summary

- ▶ Greek contact with (and influence on) Armenian largely indirect, on the basis of the written word
- ▶ Greek served as model for building a Armenian scientific, philosophical, etc. lexicon
- ▶ borrowings and calques occur

The *Yunaban Dproc*: overview

- ▶ *Յունաբան Դպրոց* (*Yunaban Dproc*) or *Hellenising School* is a cover term referring to the translations of Greek philosophical, theological and scientific texts into Armenian AND its methodological particularities
- ▶ a large corpus of research exists:
AKINIAN (1932); BOLOGNESI (2000*b,a*); CALZOLARI (1989); CLACKSON (1995); COULIE (1994); COWE (1990); JAHUKYAN (1954); LAFONTAINE AND COULIE (1983); MANANDYAN (1928); MERCIER (1978-9); MEYER (2018); MURADYAN (1971, 2012); NICHANIAN (1989); TERIAN (1982); TINTI (2012*a*)
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This kind of translation ...

... ne servait pas à transmettre le sens, mais à transmettre la lettre (NICHANIAN 1989:135)

... maintain not only the word order of the Greek, but also the form of Greek compounds and other grammatical structures (TERIAN 1980:197)

The method of the *Yunaban Dproc*

- ▶ large-scale creation of calques, e.g. ἐνέργεια ‘activity; active voice’ > ներգործութիւն
nergorcut’iwn
 - ▶ ներ- *ner-* ≈ ἐν- ‘in, inside’, cp. Arm. ներքո *nerk’o* ‘under, in’
 - ▶ գործ *gorc* ≈ ἔργον ‘work, action’
 - ▶ -ութիւն *-ut’iwn* ≈ -ια as an abstract suffix.

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- ▶ yet, Greek-Armenian correspondences are not biunique (CLACKSON 1995:124–5; also cf. TINTI 2012*b*)

ver-
der-
bac' (4x), *ap-* (3x)
tram- (3x), *hastat-* (1x)
art-
ner-
mak- (9x), *ver-* (1x)
ənd-
yar- (10x), *mat-* (2x), *tar-* (1x)
par- (5x), *bak-* (1x)
nax- (6x), *(y)ařaj-* (2x)
ař-
bař- (11x), *řar-* (5x), *řař-* (3x)
řok- (3x), *p'ař-* (2x), *par-* (1x)
ger-
stor- (4x), *ent'* (3x), *p'ař-* (1x)

ἀνά
 ἀντί
 ἀπό
 διά
 ἐκ
 ἐν
 ἐπί
 μετά
 παρά
 περί
 πρό
 πρός
 σύν
 ὑπερ
 ὑπό

-owt'iwñ *-ία, -η, -σις, -ισμός*
-akan *-ικός*
-eli *-τέον*
-ac *-μα*
-oř *-τηρ, -τωρ*
-ayin *-ιος*
-eal *-μενος*
-pēs, -bar *-ως*

An example of the *Yunaban Dproc*

ew anuan *hast(at)adrut'iwnk' en* *erku, nergorcut'iwn ew kir.*
 and noun.GEN.SG disposition.NOM.PL be.3.PL.PRS two agency.NOM.SG and Patience.NOM.SG
 Τοῦ δὲ ὁμόματος διαθέσεις εἰς δύο, ἐνέργεια καὶ πάθος,
ew *nergorcut'iwn ē* *ibr t'e **datawor**,* *əntrawl.* *ew*
 and Agency.NOM.SG be.3.SG.PRS like judge.NOM.SG judge.PRS.PTCP.NOM.SG and
 ἐνέργεια μὲν ὥς κριτῆς ὁ κρίνων,
kir *ibr t'e **dateal**,* ***datec'eal***
 Patience.NOM.SG like judge.PRF.PTCP.NOM.SG judge.PRF.PTCP.NOM.SG
 πάθος δὲ ὥς κριτός ὁ κρινόμενος

‘The dispositions of the noun are two, Agency and Patience. Agency, such as “judge”, (viz.) who is judging. Patience, such as “judgeable” (lit. “judged”), (viz.) who is judged.’

Purpose of the *Yunaban Dproc*

- ▶ given the highly literal nature of these translations, they are evidently utilitarian rather than literary
- ▶ a prevalent interpretation is that they served as *aides-mémoire* for armenophone students of the trivium

[T]he translations of the [Hellenising] School would represent the kind of texts used for certain structured courses of learning during the School's period of activity (TERIAN 1982:182)

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BUT this perspective is highly problematic in view of the Armenian version of the τέχνη γραμματική

The τέχνη γραμματική

- ▶ the τέχνη γραμματική (*The Art of Grammar*) is a concise (<3,000 words) treatise on the Greek language and its component parts
- ▶ it is usually attributed to the Alexandrian scholar Dionysios Thrax (c. 170–90 BCE), a pupil of Aristarkhos of Samothrace (c. 217–145 BCE), the Alexandrian philologist and editor of Homer
- ▶ it is generally held to be the first (European!) grammar

BUT only the first five sections are generally recognised to be old (LAW 2003:54–7)

- ▶ no relation between outline and content
- ▶ transmission issues (later passages only quoted post-4th c. CE; earliest copy from the 5th c. CE)
- ▶ quotations of Dionysios in later authors like Apollonios Dyscolos (fl. 2nd c. CE), suggesting that Dionysios did not make certain distinctions expressly made in the τέχνη (e.g. separation of the article from the pronoun; DI BENEDETTO 1990; also cf. ROBINS 1995)

Supposed structure of the τέχνη

γραμματική ἐστὶν ἐμπειρία τῶν παρὰ ποιηταῖς
τε καὶ συγγραφεῦσιν ὥς ἐπὶ τὸ πολὺ
λεγομένων.
μέρη δὲ αὐτῆς ἐστὶν ἕξ·

- ▶ πρῶτον ἀνάγνωσις ἐντρίβῃς κατὰ
προσωδίαν,
- ▶ δεύτερον ἐξηγήσις κατὰ τοὺς
ἐνυπάρχοντας ποιητικοὺς τρόπους,
- ▶ τρίτον γλωσσῶν τε καὶ ἱστοριῶν
πρόχειρος ἀπόδοσις,
- ▶ τέταρτον ἐτυμολογίας εὗρεσις,
- ▶ πέμπτον ἀναλογίας ἐκλογισμός,
- ▶ ἕκτον κρίσις ποιημάτων, ὃ δὲ κάλλιστόν
ἐστὶ πάντων τῶν ἐν τῇ τέχνῃ.

Grammar is the empirical study of the normal
usage of poets and prose writers.

It has six parts:

1. competence in reading with due regard to
prosody [=accents and vowel length];
2. interpretation, with particular attention to
the figures of speech encountered in the
text;
3. explanation in simple terms of difficult
words and allusions;
4. investigation into etymology;
5. analysis of analogy;
6. criticism of poetic works, which is the
finest part of this subject

Actual structure of the τέχνη

- | | | |
|------------------------------------|---|--|
| 1. περὶ γραμματικῆς
On grammar | On the syllable | On conjugation |
| 2. περὶ ἀναγνώσεως
On reading | 8. περὶ μακρᾶς συλλαβῆς
On long syllables | 15. περὶ μετοχῆς
On the participle |
| 3. περὶ τόνου
On tone | 9. περὶ βραχείας συλλαβῆς
On short syllables | 16. περὶ ἄρθρου
On the article |
| 4. περὶστιγμῆς
On punctuation | 10. περὶ κοινῆς συλλαβῆς
On 'common' syllables | 17. περὶ ἀντωνυμίας
On the pronoun |
| 5. περὶ ῥαψωιδίας
On recitation | 11. περὶ λέξεως
On the word | 18. περὶ προθέσεως
On the preposition |
| ----- | 12. περὶ ὀνόματος
On the noun | 19. περὶ ἐπιρρήματος
On adverbs |
| 6. περὶ στοιχείου
On elements | 13. περὶ ῥήματος
On the verb | 20. περὶ συνδέσμου
On conjunctions |
| 7. περὶ συλλαβῆς | 14. περὶ συζυγίας | |

Role of the τέχνη

- ▶ most of what constitutes the τέχνη (§§6–20) is not prefigured in §1 – one of the reasons its textual history (and thus date) is deemed problematic
- ▶ regardless of its history and authorship, it has been one if not *the* starting point for many grammatical traditions, including the Armenian one

The Art of Grammar that has come down to us under his name may or may not be authentic, but it is certainly representative of the grammatical knowledge of the time. It is a rather schematic overview of the tasks of the grammarian and the parts of speech, with many subclassifications.

(VAN BEKKUM ET AL. 1997:205)

The Armenian τέχνη

- ▶ the Armenian version of the τέχνη is
 - ▶ notably replacing Greek cultural references with Armenian ones
- NOT a translation (= Grammar of Greek, written in Armenian)
- NOT an adaptation (= Greek-based Grammar of Armenian)
 - ▶ at times adopting Greek concepts and pretending they exist in Armenian
- ▶ this mix-and-match approach calls into question its value for contemporary readers

[W]hat is the purpose or function of this translation? It is not a grammatically faithful reflection of the Greek, nor does it represent the linguistic reality of Classical Armenian so far as it is known. What is more, the changes [...] are not made explicit so that the unaware reader would not be able to make heads or tails of this text. If the intention was to reflect Armenian usage, why were passages from the Greek inapplicable to Armenian not simply left out? In earlier parts of the Armenian τέχνη, for instance, the translator has omitted a number of quotes from Homeric epic illustrating assimilatory processes in Greek which do not occur in Armenian.

(MEYER 2023:54–5)

Changing cultural references

Ὅνομά ἐστι μέρος λόγου [...] κοινῶς τε καὶ
ιδίως λεγόμενον, κοινῶς μὲν οἶον ἄνθρωπος
ἵππος, ιδίως δὲ οἶον **Σωκράτης**.

*Anun ē masn bani [...] hasarakabar ew yatkapēs.
hasarakabar orgunak mard, ew yatkapēs orgon
Pawłos.*

“A noun is a [...] part of speech, signifying something [...] common or proper; common, as *man*,
>*horse*<; proper, as |*Socrates*| <*Paul*>” (§12)

* * *

ὁμώνυμον δέ ἐστιν ὄνομα τὸ κατὰ πολλῶν
ὁμωνύμως τιθέμενον, οἶον ἐπὶ μὲν κυρίων, ὥς
Αἴας ὁ Τελαμώνιος καὶ **Αἴας ὁ Ἰλέως**

*homanun ē or i veray bac'mac' homanunaki
eleal. i veray iskič'n, orpisi **Yovhannēs**
Zak'arean ew **Yovhannēs Zebelēan***

“A homonym is a noun predicated homonymously of many things, as of proper nouns, e.g.
|Telamonian Ajax, Oïlean Ajax|<John, son of Zachary, and John, son of Zebedee>.” (§12; for more
see DE LAMBERTERIE 2022)

Simple translation

τόνος ἐστὶν ἀπήχησις φωνῆς ἐναρμονίου, ἡ
κατὰ ἀνάτασιν ἐν τῇ ὀξύειᾳ, ἡ κατὰ ὀμαλισμὸν
ἐν τῇ βαρείᾳ, ἡ κατὰ περίκλασιν ἐν τῇ
περισπωμένῃ.

*Olorak ē bac'aganč'ut'iwn patkanawor jayni, t'e
əst versastut'ean šeštiwn, t'e əst hart'ut'ean
bt'iwn, t'e əst parbekut'ean parukawn.*

“Tone [Accent] is the resonance [exclamation] of a voice endowed with harmony. It is heightened in the acute [emphasis > accute], balanced in the grave [level > grave], and broken in the circumflex [breaking > circumflex].” (§7)

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NB Armenian does not have a pitch accent.

Adaptation of Greek concepts

γράμματα ἔστιν **εἰκοσιτέσσαρα** ἀπο τοῦ α
μέχρι τοῦ ω. [...]
τούτων φωνήεντα μὲν ἔστιν **ἐπτά**· α ε η ι ο υ ω.
[...]
ἔτι δὲ τῶν συμφώνων διπλᾶ μὲν ἔστι **τρία**· ζ ξ
ψ. διπλᾶ δὲ εἴρηται, ὅτι ἐν ἑκαστον αὐτῶν ἐκ
δύο συμφώνων κύγκειται, τὸ μὲν ζ ἐκ τοῦ c καὶ
δ, τὸ δὲ ξ ἐκ τοῦ κ καὶ c, τὸ δὲ ψ ἐκ τοῦ π καὶ c.

*gir ē **eresun ew vec**‘ yaybē minč‘ew c‘k‘ē. [...]*
*ew noc‘a jaynawork‘ en **ut**‘, a e ē ə i o w ω. [...]*
*ew krknakk‘ en i soc‘anē **ut**‘. z, l, x, š, č‘, j, r, c‘.*
ew krknakk‘ asin, vasn zi mi mi iwrak‘anč‘iwr
ok‘ i soc‘anē yerkuc‘ jaynakc‘ac‘ bałkac‘eal ē,
vasn zi bałkanay‘ zayn (z) i sēē (s) ew dayē (d)
ew xēn (x) yerkuc‘ k‘makic‘ k‘ēic‘ (k‘) ew šayn
(š) yerkuc‘ sēic‘ (s) ew řayn (ř) yerkuc‘ rēic‘ (r).
noynpēs ew aylk‘n mu mu yerkuc‘ barbarakc‘ac‘
šarakac‘eal en.

“Grammata are the **thirty-six letters** of the alphabet from *ayb* to *k‘ē*. [...]

Of these, **eight** are vocalic: a e ē ə i o w ω.[...]

Of them [consonants], **eight** are double: z, l, x, š, č‘, j, r, c‘. They are called ‘double’ because each one of them is composed of two consonants, because z is composed of s and d, x of two adjoining k’s, š of two ss and ř of two rs. In like fashion the others are each built from two consonants.” (§9)

Adaptation of Armenian realities

ἄρθρον ἐστὶ μέρος λόγου πτωτικόν, προτασσόμενον
καὶ ὑποτασσόμενον τῆς κλίσεως τῶν ὀνομάτων. καὶ
ἔστι προτακτικὸν μὲν **ὀ**, ὑποτακτικὸν δὲ **ὀc**.

παρέπεται δὲ αὐτῷ τρία· γένη, ἀριθμοί, πτώσεις.
γένη μὲν οὖν εἰς τρία· **ὀ ποιητής, ἡ ποίησις, τὸ
ποίημα**.

ἀριθμοὶ τρεῖς· ἐνικός, δυϊκός, πληθυντικός· ἐνικὸς
μὲν **ὀ ἡ τό**, δυϊκὸς δὲ **τῶ τᾶ**, πληθυντικός δὲ **οἱ αἱ
τά**.

πτώσεις δὲ **ὀ τοῦ τῷ τόν ῶ**, ἡ τῆς τῇ τήν ῶ.

Yawd ē masn bani holovakan, naxadaseal ew
storadaseal nerxonarhut'ean anuanc'n. ew
naxadasakan ē ays, orgon **o**. ew storadasakan ē ays,
orzan **or**.

Ew yarewin nma aysk'. serk', t'iwk', holovk'.

Ew en serk', orgon **ararawł, ararac, araruac**.

Tiwk' erek'. ezakan: **ays, ayd, ayn**. erkuorakan:
aysu, aydu, aynov. ew yoganakan: **aysk', aydk',
aynk'**.

Ew holovk': **ays, aysr, aysm, aysu, zays, ov, aysk'**:

“An Article is a declinable part of speech prefixed or subjoined to the various cases of nouns, taking, when prefixed, the form **ὀ**, and, when subjoined, the form **ὀc**. The Genders are three, as **the creator** (m.), **the act of creation** (f.), **the creation** (n.). – The Numbers are three: Singular, Dual, and Plural. — Singular, as **ὀ, ἡ, τό <this, that, yonder>**; Dual, as **τῶ, τᾶ <?>**; Plural, as **οἱ, αἱ, τά <these, those, yonder>**. – The Cases are: **ὀ, τοῦ, τῷ, τόν, ῶ; ἡ, τῆς, τῇ, τήν, ῶ; τό, τοῦ, τῶ, τᾶ, ῶ <this, of this, to/at this, with this, this (object), oh!, these>**.” (§16)

Short summary

- ▶ the Armenian version of the τέχνη uses a number of different translations strategies
- ▶ this mixture of straight translation, adaptation of Greek concepts and Greek-based creativity makes it essentially unusable as either a translation of a Greek grammar, an Armenian grammar, or a study aid
- ▶ one might hope that these idiosyncrasies would be addressed, corrected, or contextualised in later commentaries ...

Extant Armenian commentaries

- ▶ six more or less complete and extensive commentaries are attested (ADONTZ 1970; COWE 2020):
 - ▶ pseudo-David (the Invincible) – 6th c.
 - ▶ Step'anos Siwnec'i – 7th–8th c.
 - ▶ Movsēs K'ert'ol – 8th c.
 - ▶ Hamam Arewelc'i – 9th c.
 - ▶ Grigor Magistros – 10th–11th c.
 - ▶ one unattributed commentary
- ▶ alas, from a linguistic perspective, these commentaries are rarely directly insightful – like many of their Greek counterparts ...

Greek commentaries

τούτων φωνήεντα μέν ἔστιν ἑπτὰ· α ε η ι ο υ ω.
φωνήεντα δὲ λέγεται, ὅτι φωνὴν ἅφ' ἑαυτῶν
ἀποτελεῖ.

Of these [elements], seven are vocalic
(endowed with speech, vowels): α ε η ι ο υ ω.
They are called vocalic because they form a
complete sound by themselves. (§6)

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ἀποτελεῖ.

Καὶ τί δήποτε ὁ τεχνικὸς τῶν φωνηέντων τὸν
ἀριθμὸν μέχρι τοῦ ἑπτὰ ὀρίζειται; – Καὶ φαμεν
ὅτι ἴσα αὐτὰ τῷ ἀριθμῷ τῶν χορδῶν τῆς λύρας
τοῦ Ἀπόλλωνος ἐποίησεν, ἢ κατὰ μίμησιν τῶν
ἑπτὰ ἀστέρων τῶν πλανήτων τοῦ οὐρανοῦ·
πλάνητες γὰρ εἰσιν ἑπτὰ, Κρόνος, Ζεὺς, Ἄρης,
ἥλιος, Ἀφροδίτη, Ἑρμῆς καὶ σελήνη. Ταῦτα
γὰρ τὰ φωνήεντα τοῖς πλάνησιν ἀνάκεινται·
καὶ τὸ μὲν α φασι τῇ σελήνῃ ἀνακεῖσθαι, τὸ δὲ ε
τῷ Ἑρμῇ, τὸ δὲ η τῇ Ἀφροδίτῃ, τὸ δὲ ι τῷ ἥλιῳ,
τὸ δὲ ο τῷ Ἄρει, τὸ δὲ υ τῷ Δίῃ, τὸ δὲ ω τῷ
Κρόνῳ.

Of these [elements], seven are vocalic
(endowed with speech, vowels): α ε η ι ο υ ω.
They are called vocalic because they form a
complete sound by themselves. (§6)

Why does the writer of the τέχνη define the
number of the vowels as seven? – Our answer
is either that he made them equal to the
number of strings of Apollo's lyre, or that they
imitate the planets of the sky, for the planets
are seven in number: Saturn, Jupiter, Mars,
Sun, Venus, Mercury, and Moon. The vowels
depend on the planets: they say that *a* depends
on the moon, *e* on Mercury, *ē* on Venus, *i* on
the Sun, *o* on Mars, *u* on Jupiter, and *ō* on
Saturn. (*Schol.Dion.Thrax* 197,33–198,6)

Glossary

ADDITAMENTUM ARMENIACUM	
ԲԱՌԻՔ ԲԵՐԱԿԱՆԻՆ	
Ա.]	
վերծանութիւն, ընթերցողութիւն.	
ներկուտ, ըստկուտ, կամ կոխ, կամ կիրթ.	5
ըստ ներգոյս, ըստ ի ներքս գոլոյ.	
առժեռն, ժեռն ի ժեռն.	
բացատրութիւն, ի բաց տալ.	
դատումն, ընտրութիւն կամ քննութիւն.	
ներարհստիս, ըստ արուեստիս.	10
Բ.]	
անվթար, անահոկ, կամ անբիծ, կամ անսխալ.	
անաջընթերցութիւն, առաջի բերումն.	
ըստ ենթադատութեան, ըստ քննութեան կամ ըստ նմանաբանութեան.	15
ըստ առողջանութեան, ըստ առասացութեան.	
ըստ տրոհութեան, ըստ որոշողութեան.	
պարունակ, որ ի ներքս փակէ.	
ողբերգութիւն, ընդ ողբսն գլուսոյ նուազսն խառնեալ.	
կատակերգութիւն, զկատականացն նուազել խասս.	20
դիւցազնաբար, որպէս դիւցազանց վայելէ.	
դամբանական, զերեզմանանական.	

(ADONTZ 1970:57)

Pseudo-David on the accent

Isk olorakn miayn banakanis ar i patkanawor uneloy jayn, ew omanc' canawt' leal ar i krt'ut'enē, orpēs i yunakan lezuin, isk ayl azgac'n oč' ewš. (ADONTZ 1970:90–1)

“Tone, however, is comprehensible only on the basis of its having a suitable sound; in some [languages] it is known / can be learnt through/from instruction, like in Greek, but in [the languages] of other people not even that.”

- implicit indication that Armenian and Greek are not following the same pattern

On the article

“The article is a is a declinable part of speech, preposed and subordinate to the declension of nouns. The article, **like in the Greek tongue so in ours**, no longer a lexical word, but (only) some sort of small particle. The article is like a sharp/acute word joined to something in effect, which should work analogously (in case?) and properly. **It is found in Greek at the beginning of the word, as in “Ο (ὁ) Peter”**. There are masculine and feminine and neuter varieties, likewise for the singular and the plural. **But as for Armenian, they are at the end, according to the following set of three examples: *δ/ή, δ/ήη, δ/ήυ*, which is the deictic marker of visible things**. For if you say, “A horse came”, you pointed out nothing, but by adding an article, as if you say, “That horse came”, you indicated ‘there’. But **no other indications/varieties (cases etc.?) of the article are found in Armenian, but they are given to complete the paragraph.**” (Pseudo-David, tr. from ADONTZ 1970:115)

“In another (the other?) language, there are many (kinds of) articles, **but in ours only few**, for though there are cases and numbers, they **do not leave any traces** as to their type (on the article).” (Movsēs K’ert’oġ, tr. from ADONTZ 1970:150)

On the article

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- ▶ direct comparison and contrast of Greek and Armenian
- ▶ *de facto* correction of the Armenian version, explicit in Pseudo-David
- ▶ explanation of the superfluous additions

More on the article

“The article, in concord, **is joined to the noun in many cases**, like a hilt of a sword which is put to work. According to **Greek (grammar), it is preposed to many (words)**, as we wrote above in the general introduction. For when they want to use a masculine word (about some man), they prepose the article as follows, *ὁ* Kostandianos, *ὁ* Grigorios. And this masculine article with *ὁ* is preposed, and likewise many other (things) are indicated by the preposition of the article. **As for our (grammatical habits), we are not used to do this (kind of thing)** frequently or in many instances by preposing the article, but we only say O Gēorg, O Grigor, O Trdat. And so, the *նի* is preposed to each masculine (noun).” (Grigor Magistros, tr. from ADONTZ 1970:246)

Grigor Magistros and the Platos

“But the combinations of the article are something like this. In the nominative singular, **Plato** (**Պլատոն Platon**); in the genitive, of Plato; in the dative and instrumental, to/with Plato; in the accusative, Plato; in the vocative, o Plato.

In the nominative plural, **Platos** (**Պլատոնք Platonk'**); in the genitive (from) Platos; in the dative and ablative, with the Platos; in the vocative, o Platos. In the feminine singular, nominative **Platoness** (**Պլատոնուհի Platonuhi**), genitive of Platoness, dative and instrumental with Platoness, accusative Platoness, vocative o Platoness. ...

The neuter (form) of the noun of the singular, nominative **Plato-thing** (**Պլատոնուկ Platonuk**), genitive of the Plato-thing, ...” (Grigor Magistros, tr. from ADONTZ 1970:247)

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- ▶ this does not, to our best knowledge, correspond to Armenian linguistic reality – there are no genders; the supposed neuter ending was not productive
- ▶ given that this appears in the commentary on the article, is it meant to reflect what **in Greek** can be achieved by means of the article

Conclusions I

Greek and Armenian in general

- ▶ the phylogenetic relationship between the two languages is less strong than used to be assumed
- ▶ loanwords outside academia are restricted to administrative and elementary religious terminology

Hellenising Armenian

- ▶ in the creation of a scientific vocabulary and the translation of Greek texts, the Greek language served as a model
- ▶ this model was often followed to the letter, many adopted or created terms have survived into the modern language
- ▶ these translations were often not easily comprehensible (see comments, glossaries)
- ▶ yet, they cannot have served as simple crib-sheets either

Conclusions II

The Armenian *τέχνη*

- ▶ combines a mixture of different strategies – simple translation, adaptation of Greek material to Armenian realities, adopt of Greek concepts despite Armenian realities
- ▶ consequently, it is neither a grammar of Greek nor of Armenian and reflects neither language entirely accurately

The commentaries

- ▶ show clear awareness of differences between the Armenian and Greek languages, and point these out explicitly
- ▶ they do not, however, correct the translation or suggest it is problematic
- ▶ at times, they produce similarly unexpected explanations / paradigms / analogies without obvious reasoning
- ▶ in number and style, they indicate that the *τέχνη* continued to be used for at least half a millennium

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